TEXORA · LECTURE SHEET

Sample Development and Merchandising Sourcing

How samples are developed stage by stage until bulk production is authorised, why sourcing is a merchandising function, the strategies behind it, materials management for quick response, and how the merchandiser coordinates the production house and the export house.

TE-4104 · APPAREL MERCHANDISING AND INTERNATIONAL TRADE · TOPIC 3 · LEVEL 4 TERM 1

1. Merchandising activities in sample development

A **sample** is a garment made before bulk production to prove — to buyer and factory alike — that the design can be made as specified, at the costed consumption, in the required quality. Sampling is not a tailoring exercise; it is the order's risk-removal process, and the merchandiser runs it as a managed sequence:

1. **Receive and analyse the tech pack** (Topic 2); list every material, measurement and construction requirement the sample must demonstrate.
2. **Source sample materials.** Order sample-yardage fabric and trims — in the correct quality, or a declared substitute where the buyer allows it for early stages.
3. **Issue the sample programme.** Pattern, cutting and sewing instructions with dates from the T&A calendar; each sample type has a dispatch deadline.
4. **Check before dispatch.** Measure the sample against the spec, check construction and appearance, and record deviations honestly — a sample sent with a known fault wastes a full approval cycle.
5. **Dispatch with documentation.** Sample, measurement chart as-made, material details and the merchandiser's comments travel together.
6. **Process comments and corrections.** Buyer comments are translated into pattern / construction corrections; the next sample embodies them; every comment is tracked to closure.
7. **Cost confirmation.** As samples approach approval, consumption measured on the real pattern replaces the estimate, and the cost sheet (Topic 4) is confirmed or re-negotiated before bulk.

2. The sample stages

SAMPLE	PURPOSE	WHAT IS JUDGED
Proto / development sample	First physical version of the design, often in substitute fabric.	Design interpretation, silhouette, basic construction feasibility.
Fit sample	Made in correct or near-correct fabric and checked on a fit model / dress form.	Measurements, balance, ease and fit; pattern corrections are decided here.
Size-set sample	One garment in every size (or the specified range of sizes).	Grading between sizes — that every size is a correct enlargement / reduction of the approved fit.
Pre-production (PP) sample	Made in bulk fabric and trims, by bulk methods, before production starts.	The complete product as bulk will be: materials, construction, measurements, appearance. PP approval authorises bulk.
Production / shipment sample	Garments taken from actual bulk production.	That bulk output matches the approved PP sample; retained as evidence of what was shipped.
Photo / salesman sample (SMS)	Samples for photography, catalogues and sales representatives, where the buyer's programme requires them.	Appearance and colour accuracy for selling, ahead of bulk delivery.
Counter / reference sample	The approved sample retained by each party.	The reference standard for inspection and for settling disputes.

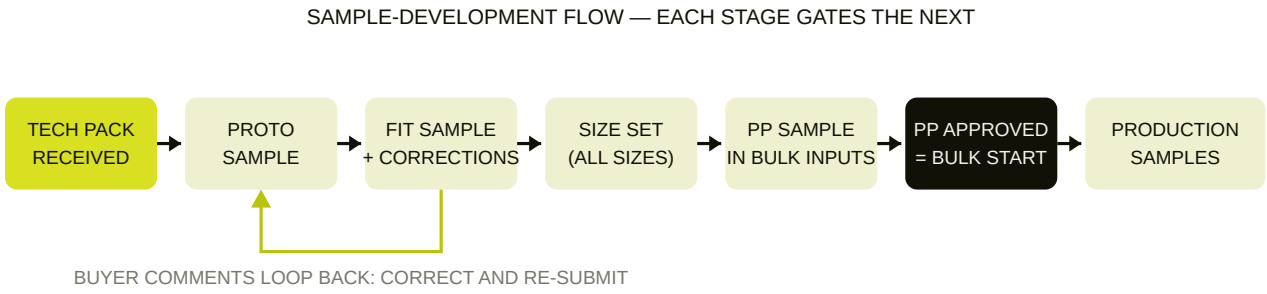


Figure 1 — Sample-development flow. No stage is decorative: proto proves the idea, fit proves the pattern, size set proves the grading, PP proves the bulk product — and only PP approval releases production.

3. The need for sourcing

Sourcing is the selection and management of the suppliers of fabric, trims and processes an order needs. Even a factory with its own knitting or weaving rarely makes everything: interlinings, buttons,

zips, threads, labels, specialised fabrics and wash / print processes come from outside. Sourcing is needed because:

- **Materials dominate cost.** Fabric alone is typically the largest line of the cost sheet (Topic 4), so supplier choice decides competitiveness.
- **The buyer specifies quality, not always a supplier.** The factory must find sources that meet the specification and the test requirements — and prove that they do.
- **Lead time is bought.** A cheaper source with a longer, unreliable delivery can cost more in delay than it saves in price.
- **Compliance and testing** requirements (fibre content, colour fastness, restricted substances where specified) must be satisfied by the source, with evidence.
- **Capacity and continuity.** An order — and a repeat programme — needs sources that can deliver the full quantity, again, to the same standard.

4. Sourcing strategies

STRATEGY	MEANING AND USE
Full-package sourcing	The factory sources all materials against the buyer's specification (the FOB model of Topic 2). Maximum factory control — and responsibility.
Nominated sourcing	The buyer nominates specific mills / suppliers for key inputs; the factory buys from them. Protects the buyer's quality standard; the factory manages timing.
Local vs. imported sourcing	Local sources shorten lead time and simplify logistics; imported sources may offer qualities or prices unavailable locally. The choice is made per input, weighing price, lead time and risk.
Single vs. multiple sourcing	One approved source simplifies consistency; a qualified second source insures against failure. Critical inputs usually justify a back-up.
Long-term partnership	Developing core mills as partners — shared forecasts, priority capacity, joint problem-solving — instead of re-tendering every order.
Greige / forward booking	Booking base fabric (or greige) ahead of confirmed orders for core programmes, converting to colours on order — the material basis of quick response (Section 5).

5. Materials management for quick response

Quick Response (QR) is the strategy of shortening the time between a selling signal and replenished goods, so that orders follow real demand more closely. For the merchandiser, QR is mostly **materials**

management, because fabric lead time is usually the longest element of the order:

- **Pre-position long-lead materials.** Hold or book greige fabric, core yarns and standard trims for running programmes before the detailed order lands.
- **Postpone differentiation.** Dye, print and finish as late as possible: keep material in the most flexible form (greige, undyed) until colour and style are confirmed.
- **Standardise inputs.** Fewer fabric qualities and trim variants across styles means larger, faster, shared bookings.
- **Share information early.** Forecasts, range plans and provisional quantities reach mills before POs reach the factory; information lead time substitutes for material lead time.
- **Measure material readiness, not only production.** The T&A calendar (Topic 2) tracks booking, approval of lab dips / strike-offs, and in-house dates as first-class milestones.

> **QR PRINCIPLE**
>
> You cannot sew faster than fabric arrives. Quick response is won in materials — flexible stock, late differentiation and early information — weeks before the sewing line is involved.

6. Coordination with the production house and the export house

Two organisations must move as one. The **production house** (factory) controls pattern, cutting, sewing, finishing, capacity and quality; the **export house** (the exporting / merchandising office — in some businesses a separate buying or export firm) controls the buyer relationship, costing, documentation and shipment. The merchandiser is their coordination point:

COORDINATION TASK	HOW IT IS DONE
One specification	The export side issues the confirmed tech pack and PP comments to production in writing; production confirms feasibility and dates before acceptance.
One plan	A single T&A calendar owned by merchandising; production reports actual progress against it; slippage is escalated the day it appears.
Pre-production meeting	Before bulk: merchandising, production, quality and sourcing review the approved PP sample, materials status, construction risks and inspection plan together.
Approvals without delay	The export house chases buyer approvals (lab dips, strike-offs, PP) so production is never idle waiting for a decision it cannot influence.

Shipment readiness	Production confirms packing completion; the export house aligns vessel booking, inspection and documents (Topics 5 and 8) to that confirmed date — not to the hoped date.

Glossary

TERM	MEANING
Proto sample	The first sample made from a design, proving interpretation and feasibility.
PP sample	Pre-production sample in bulk materials by bulk methods; its approval authorises production.
Sourcing	Selecting and managing the suppliers of fabrics, trims and processes for an order.
Nominated supplier	A supplier specified by the buyer from whom the factory must buy a given input.
Quick Response	A strategy of shortening replenishment time through flexible materials, late differentiation and early information sharing.
Lab dip / strike-off	A dyed fabric sample / printed trial submitted for colour and design approval before bulk.

Key points and summary

- Sample development is a gated sequence — proto, fit, size set, PP, production samples — each stage removing a named risk; PP approval alone releases bulk.
- The merchandiser sources sample materials, checks before dispatch, processes comments to closure, and confirms cost on the real pattern.
- Sourcing is needed because materials dominate cost, buyers specify quality, lead time is bought with the material, and compliance must be evidenced.
- Strategies include full-package vs. nominated, local vs. imported, single vs. multiple sources, partnerships and forward greige booking.
- Quick response is materials management: pre-positioned flexible stock, postponed differentiation, standardisation and early information.
- Production house and export house are coordinated through one specification, one T&A plan, a pre-production meeting and disciplined approvals.

Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. A buyer approves the fit sample but the factory starts bulk cutting before PP approval, to save time. What risk has the factory accepted, in one or two sentences?
2. Why is a PP sample required to be made in bulk fabric rather than the substitute fabric used for the proto?
3. An order’s fabric lead time is the longest activity. Give two QR materials actions that shorten the effective lead time without changing the mill’s production speed.
4. State one advantage and one disadvantage of buyer-nominated sourcing from the factory’s point of view.

Answer key

1. Bulk fabric and trims may behave differently from the approved fit sample’s inputs, so the bulk product may not match what the buyer approved — the factory bears the cost of any rejection or rework alone.
2. Because PP is the proof of the actual product: bulk fabric’s weight, shrinkage, shade and handling decide measurements and appearance, and only a PP in those inputs can authorise production safely.
3. Book greige fabric forward for the programme and dye to order (postponed differentiation); share the buyer’s forecast with the mill early so the mill pre-positions yarn / capacity. Either action removes waiting from the critical path.
4. Advantage: quality and standard are pre-assured by the buyer’s own nomination, reducing approval disputes. Disadvantage: the factory cannot switch to a faster or cheaper equivalent if the nominated source is late or expensive.

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